

History—Mughal Empire

Subject: History

The Mughal Empire was a major early modern empire in South Asia. It was founded in 1526 when Babur defeated Ibrahim Lodi at the First Battle of Panipat. Babur belonged to a family connected to both Timur and Genghis Khan, and he brought Central Asian political traditions, military experience, and cultural tastes into northern India. The empire did not become stable immediately. Babur's successor, Humayun, temporarily lost power to Sher Shah Suri, whose administration and road systems later influenced Mughal governance. Humayun returned to Delhi in 1555, but his reign was brief; his son Akbar inherited the throne in 1556.

Akbar transformed the Mughal state from a fragile conquest into a more durable empire. He expanded into northern and central India through warfare, diplomacy, alliances, and negotiated arrangements with regional rulers. His administration used the mansabdari system, in which officials held ranks that reflected their status and military responsibilities. Many officials were paid through assignments of revenue rather than through permanent ownership of land. The system allowed the emperor to reward service and move officials, but it also required careful supervision. Revenue assessment became more systematic under officials associated with Raja Todar Mal. Taxes were connected to agricultural production, and the state depended heavily on the countryside to support the army and bureaucracy.

Akbar's rule is also remembered for policies that attempted to manage religious and cultural diversity. The empire contained Muslims, Hindus, Jains, Christians, and people following many local traditions. Akbar abolished certain taxes on non-Muslims, included Rajput and other local elites in imperial service, and held discussions with scholars of different faiths. His policy of *sulh-i kul*, often translated as universal peace, expressed an ideal of tolerance and political inclusion. This did not mean that conflict disappeared or that all subjects had equal power. It meant that the ruler sought loyalty and order across religious communities rather than relying only on one group.

Mughal culture developed through interaction among Persian, Central Asian, Indian, and regional traditions. Persian was an important language of administration and literature, while many local languages continued to flourish. Mughal painting combined fine detail, portraiture, manuscript illustration, and interest in plants, animals, and court life. Architecture included forts, gardens, mosques, tombs, audience halls, and planned imperial complexes. Fatehpur Sikri, Agra Fort, Humayun's Tomb, and the Taj Mahal demonstrate the importance of geometry, symmetry, calligraphy, stonework, and monumental patronage. Such buildings were also political statements: they communicated authority, wealth, dynastic memory, and the ruler's connection with a larger imperial tradition.

Jahangir continued many administrative and artistic traditions, while his court became known for painting and natural-history observation. Shah Jahan is associated with a highly ceremonial court and major architectural projects, including the Taj Mahal, built as a mausoleum for Mumtaz

Mahal. The beauty and expense of these projects reflected imperial power, but construction and military campaigns required large revenues. Aurangzeb expanded Mughal territory farther south and ruled for almost half a century. His reign involved prolonged wars in the Deccan, tensions with regional powers, and debates about the relationship between Islamic law, imperial policy, and the empire's diverse population.

The empire's later weakening had several causes. Long wars placed pressure on revenue and administration. Provincial governors and military elites gained greater independence, while regional states such as the Marathas, Sikhs, and several successor kingdoms strengthened. Court politics, succession struggles, economic pressures, and changing military technology also mattered. European trading companies became increasingly influential during the eighteenth century, although they were not the only cause of Mughal decline. The empire did not vanish in a single moment; imperial authority contracted gradually, and Mughal rulers continued to hold symbolic importance in Delhi until the British removed the last emperor after the uprising of 1857. Mughal history therefore includes conquest, negotiation, administration, cultural synthesis, regional diversity, and gradual political fragmentation.